



ONCE AGAIN XVIII

OFFICIAL LEAGUE GUIDELINES

2026-27 Season · ESPN League 56088 · 20 Teams · Commissioner: Kene Okeke

1. KEY DATES & THE MONEY

This section is new for 2026-27. **NEW 2026-27**

The buy-in, the deadlines and the consequences for missing them are now written into the rulebook instead of living in the group chat.

1.1 Key dates

Date	What is due	Detail
Sat Sep 26, 2026	\$100 deposit	Non-refundable. Holds your team for the season.
Sat Oct 17, 2026 · 7:30 PM ET	Remaining \$300 balance	Due before the draft clock starts.
Sat Oct 17, 2026 · 7:30 PM ET	LIVE DRAFT	Snake draft, 20 teams, on ESPN.
Mon Feb 15, 2027 · 12:00 PM ET	Trade deadline	Set in the ESPN league settings.
End of Week 19	Regular season ends	19 matchup periods. Top 12 teams make the playoffs.

1.2 Buy-in

- ▶ The buy-in is **\$400 per team** for the 2026-27 season.
- ▶ A **\$100 deposit** is due by Friday, September 26, 2026. The deposit is non-refundable once the draft order is generated.
- ▶ The remaining **\$300** is due by draft night, Saturday, October 17, 2026 at 7:30 PM ET.
- ▶ The commissioner will post a ledger PDF to the headboard each week showing who has paid. Payment status is public inside the league — the amounts are not a secret and disputes get settled against the ledger.
- ▶ Every fine collected during the season is added to the same pot and paid out at the end of the year.

1.3 What happens if you do not pay

This is the part that did not exist before. **NEW 2026-27**

- ▶ Deposit not received by Sept 26: **\$25 late fee**, and your seat is offered to the waiting list.
- ▶ Balance not paid by draft night: you draft, but you are **locked out of all transactions** — no adds, drops, waivers or trades — until the balance clears. A late fee of \$25 per week applies.
- ▶ A team carrying an unpaid balance past Week 4 is **ineligible for the playoffs and forfeits any winnings**, regardless of record. The team stays in the league so the schedule is not broken.
- ▶ A GM who leaves the league owing money does not get an invite back the following season until the balance is settled.

2. FINE SCHEDULE

The fines were scattered across five sections of the old rulebook. They are consolidated here. **AMENDED**

Infraction	Fine	Snitch	To pot	Notes
Unset lineup	\$50	\$25	\$25	One free reminder per season first.
Illegal IR — commissioner not notified	\$75	\$25	\$50	Most recent pickup is also dropped.
Holding a player on IR past 4 weeks	\$75	—	\$75	A player is also dropped from the roster.
Posting a duplicate trade poll	\$25	—	\$25	Also burns one of your free "30s".
3rd use of the 30-minute reversal	\$50	—	\$50	No requests permitted after the 3rd.
Accidental drop reversal, 2nd through 5th use	\$50	—	\$50	Must be paid before the transaction is reversed.
Late deposit	\$25	—	\$25	New for 2026-27.
Late balance, per week	\$25	—	\$25	New for 2026-27.

All fines are logged in the league ledger. A fine is considered outstanding until it is marked paid in that ledger.

3. TRADES

- ▶ Once a trade is accepted, both participants have 5 minutes from acceptance to put up the poll. Otherwise the trade is vetoed and cannot be re-accepted for 24 hours.
- ▶ The poll title must show the time the trade was accepted and the names of the players involved. Example:
4:30 pm — Anthony Edwards for Paul George.

A poll is titled incorrectly — and therefore vetoed for 24 hours — if:

- A player name is spelled completely incorrectly, at the commissioner's discretion if GMs are confused. This applies to players who share a common last name where nobody can tell who is who.
- Only a last name is given when another player in the league shares that last name.
- The time or am/pm is wrong. Military time is acceptable.
- ▶ 12 vetoes are required to take a trade down. Vetoes are counted and executed by the commissioner — ESPN's automatic veto is set to zero, so the league vote is what governs.
- ▶ A team must wait 7 days before trading a free agent it just picked up. Waiver pickups are eligible to be traded at any time.
- ▶ Voting closes 30 minutes before the 24-hour window expires. A GM who believes he voted in time must send the commissioner a screenshot.
- ▶ If a player is injured during the review period, the GM receiving that player may cancel the trade without fault. **If you are trading for a player already listed DTD or O, you take on full risk of that player regardless of any updated timeline.**
- ▶ Posting a duplicate poll costs the owner who posted it twice **\$25**, and removes one free "30".
- ▶ Teams involved in a pending trade may not create a new post or any other poll until the review period is over.
- ▶ If you accept a trade and change your mind, you have 30 minutes to alert the commissioner or show proof you tried to reach him. The 2nd "30" is free. The 3rd costs \$50. After the 3rd, no further requests are permitted.
- ▶ Extended trade review: any two teams that exceed 5 trades with each other in a season enter a **48-hour extended review** for the league.
- ▶ The trade limit is **30 trades per season**, excluding draft-pick trading.
- ▶ The trade deadline is Monday, February 15, 2027 at 12:00 PM ET, as set in ESPN. **NEW 2026-27**

4. MATCHUPS & TIEBREAKERS

The league plays 11 scoring categories, so a 5-5-1 split is the common tie.

4.1 Regular season

- ▶ If a matchup finishes 5-5-1, the tiebreaker is total points.
- ▶ If both teams have the same points, the **Jabari Brown Clause** now applies in the regular season as well: rebounds, then assists. **AMENDED**
- ▶ If teams are still level after points, rebounds and assists, the result stands as an official tie. There will be no readjustment of statistics unless ESPN does so on its own.

4.2 Playoffs

- ▶ 12 of 20 teams make the playoffs.
- ▶ If a playoff matchup ends 5-5-1, the tiebreaker is points. **Jabari Brown Clause:** if points are tied, the next tiebreaker is rebounds; if rebounds are tied, the next is assists.
- ▶ ESPN allows the commissioner to adjust the winner of a playoff matchup, and he will do so to enforce the clause above.

5. WAIVERS & FREE AGENT PICKUPS

- ▶ If you drop a player by accident, you have 30 minutes to inform the commissioner to reverse the transaction.
- ▶ The first reversal each season is free.
- ▶ After the free use, a reversal costs **\$50**. The transaction is not processed until the \$50 is paid. The \$50 goes to the pot. This request may be used a maximum of 4 times.
- ▶ If another team picks up the player at the same time as, or before, you notify the commissioner, **the transaction cannot be reversed**.
- ▶ Waivers run on a 24-hour cycle. There is no season limit on acquisitions. **NEW 2026-27**

6. INJURED RESERVE — RULES & REGULATIONS

ESPN gives each team a single IR slot. The token system below is a league rule enforced by the commissioner, not by ESPN — which is exactly why notification is mandatory.

- ▶ A player with any injury is eligible for IR for a **maximum of 4 weeks**.
 - If you use IR for an illness, that counts as a token.
 - You may use IR at any time after the player is injured.
 - If the player is out for less than 4 weeks, the token is spent and cannot be redeemed for the remaining weeks.
 - If you use the IR designation and the player's DTD or O tag is removed within 24 hours, the token is redeemable for full use again.
- ▶ The IR designation may be used **4 times** during the regular season.
- ▶ One token per player. Leftover weeks are not redeemable after use.
 - If you reactivate a player within the 4-week window and he is reinjured within 24 hours, you may use the rest of the time on that token.
- ▶ Playoff teams are awarded 3 fresh IR designations at the playoff reset. The same rules apply.
- ▶ Holding a player longer than the 4-week maximum is a **\$75 fine** and a player is dropped from the team — the most recent pickup.
- ▶ If a player returns and is reinjured, you must spend another token on him. You cannot use leftover weeks from the old token.
- ▶ The owner must notify the commissioner every time the IR spot is used, for any reason. If the commissioner finds an IR spot used without notification, the most recently added player via free agency or waivers is dropped immediately and a **\$75 fine** is issued.
- ▶ Every team using an IR spot will be dated on the headboard.
- ▶ **The player must be on your team at the time of the injury. You cannot draft, pick up or trade for an injured player and then add him to IR.**

- ▶ All fines go to the earnings pot.
- ▶ The player must be reactivated before the first game on the expiration date.
- ▶ Only players carrying the "O" designation may be placed on IR, due to the ESPN settings.
- ▶ If you trade a player who is on IR, your token still counts for the use after the player has left your team.

If you do not use your IR tokens by playoff time, you lose them.

7. LINE-UPS

- ▶ If you have an issue placing a player in your lineup before games start, or you forgot to set your lineup, you have 30 minutes to contact the commissioner. Otherwise it counts as a fine due.
- ▶ Players who are game-time decisions or questionable prior to the game are **not eligible** for this fix.
- ▶ Players dropped by accident within 2 minutes of the lineup lock will not have that transaction reversed.
- ▶ Unset lineups get one free reminder per season. After that, each unset lineup is a **\$50 charge** if it is not reported by that team within 30 minutes.

8. SNITCH CASES

- ▶ Whoever brings an unset lineup to the commissioner's attention before he catches it gets \$25 added to their earnings. That \$25 comes out of the fine paid by the offending GM.
- ▶ Whoever reports an illegal IR before the commissioner catches it gets \$25 added to their earnings. The rest of the fine goes to the pot.
- ▶ Each snitch has a personal reference code. The commissioner tallies winnings on the headboard using that code.
- ▶ Reference codes for 2026-27 are listed in the league ledger, in the format **OA18-XVIII##**. **NEW 2026-27**

9. COMMISSIONER, DISPUTES & CONDUCT

New section. **NEW 2026-27**

9.1 Conflict of interest

- ▶ The commissioner also manages a team. On any ruling that directly affects his own team — a trade veto involving his roster, a matchup adjustment in his own game, a fine against him — he does not rule alone.
- ▶ Such rulings go to a vote of the three most recent champions who are not party to the dispute. Majority decides. For 2026-27 that panel is Gaga Ophori, Ugo Okeke and Shomari Rawlins.

9.2 Appeals

- ▶ Any GM may appeal a ruling within 24 hours by posting on the headboard. An appeal needs 6 GMs to second it before it goes to a league vote.
- ▶ A league vote runs 24 hours and is decided by simple majority of votes cast. The commissioner does not vote unless there is a tie.

9.3 Tanking and roster abandonment

- ▶ With 12 of 20 teams making the playoffs, 8 teams are eliminated with weeks to play. Fielding a deliberately incomplete lineup after elimination is treated as an unset lineup and fined accordingly.
- ▶ A team that goes 14 consecutive days with no transactions and at least one unset lineup is deemed abandoned. The commissioner may set that team's lineup for the remainder of the season so it does not distort the playoff race.
- ▶ Collusion — trades made to strengthen one team without fair return, or lineup decisions made to favour another GM — voids the trade and forfeits that GM's winnings for the season.

10. IN-SEASON UPDATES, RULE ADJUSTMENTS & CORRECTIONS

This section is for any conflict that occurs during the season that requires a rule to be mandated or installed for future use.

Date	Ruling	Applies from